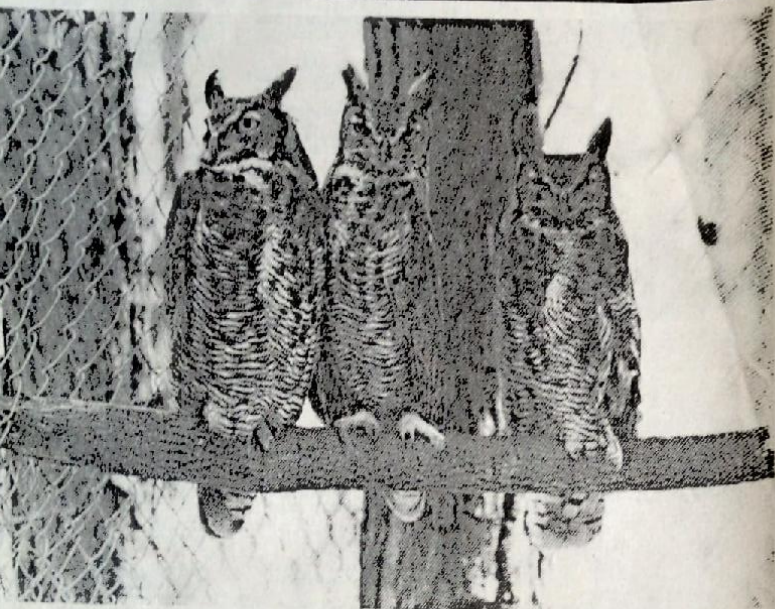




THREE GREAT-HORNED OWLS HISS AT A VISITOR TO THE RAPTOR CENTER

Staff Photos by Neil Furr

Birds Of Prey Rehabilitated At Carolina Raptor Center

By NEIL FURR
 Staff Writer

Many people in Iredell County have had the experience of driving at night through Allison's Woods or some other spooky stretch of forest and suddenly having a huge, flapping bird almost fly into the windshield.

While such an occasion can be a startling one for a driver, it can be fateful for a raptor, or bird of prey. These birds, especially owls, which are attracted by small animals seeking the warmth of the asphalt, often hunt near the road at night and are sometimes struck and maimed by vehicles.

Raptors injured in such a way do not have to be left flopping by the roadside to die, however. And neither do birds of prey winged by hunters, or their orphaned little ones. There is an agency dedicated to restoring injured birds to health and returning them to the wild, when possible.

That agency, the Carolina Raptor Center, is located in the Latta Plantation on Mountain Island Lake near Huntersville and is

worth a visit even if a person has never had a "close encounter of the bird kind" on a lonely road at night. The present facility includes live exhibits of non-releasable birds of prey. Thousands of school children and other visitors each year enjoy getting to meet Buffy, an "imprinted" screech owl who thinks she's a person; Gilligan, a non-releasable osprey; and Queen Charlotte and her shy courtier, Prince Raleigh, a pair of non-releasable bald eagles.

What visitors don't get to see, and for good reason, are the hundreds of other birds being readied for their return to the wild. These releasable birds are kept separate from the rest and away from humans because it is healthier for a raptor not to get too used to humans, or to lose its fear of them. Also in an area away from the trafficking of visitors is the nesting area of Betsy and Chrysler, a pair of bonded golden eagles whom Raptor Center personnel hope will conceive another egg this year. Last year's egg was cracked, unfortunately. Such mating in captivity is rare.

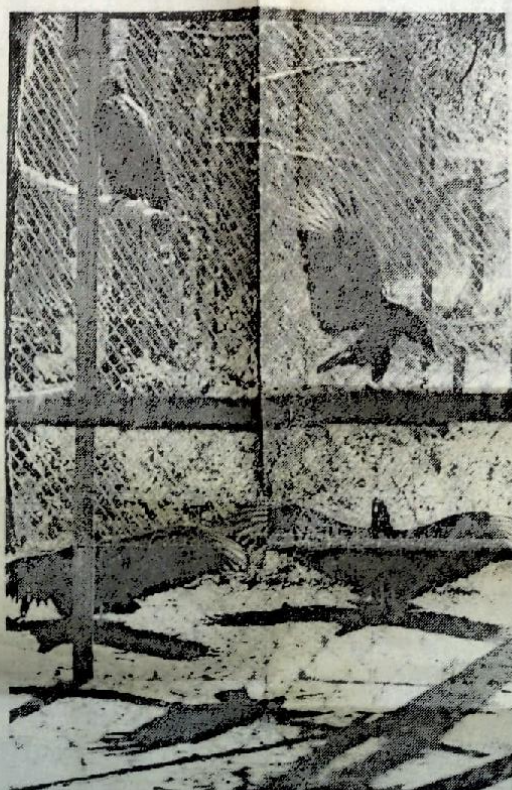
Thus, the Raptor Center has a dual purpose. For one thing, it is dedicated to the environmental education of the public. After a quiet stroll through the habitats, one has a greater appreciation for the sleek kestrels, the nervous ospreys, the winking owls, the haughty eagles and even the communal turkey vultures. Really now, how could anybody even think of taking a shot at a hawk named Bunky?

The other purpose, of course, is the conservation of raptors through rehabilitation, reproduction and research. Over 40 percent of the injured raptors brought into the center are eventually returned to the wild. Last year, for instance, six bald eagles, some of which had been shot down in spite of potential \$20,000 fines for doing so, were brought into the center.

For more information, to arrange a tour, or to find out what to do with an injured bird, call the Carolina Raptor Center at (704) 875-6521, or write them at Carolina Raptor Center, Inc., P.O. Box 16443, Charlotte, N.C. 28297-6443.



BUNKY, A RED-TAILED HAWK, AWAITA A MOUSE LUNCH



VULTURES WARM THEIR WINGS IN THE SUN



SHY BARRED OWLS PEEK AROUND A CORNER